

UMBRELLA SPECIES

Many people are eager to protect certain rare animals such as the giant panda, but are not so concerned about the fate of less famous species. However, pandas cannot survive unless the ecosystem that supports them survives too. By working to protect panda habitats, we may also ensure the survival of other animals and plants.



▲ PROTECTING THE PANDA

Giving the giant panda a future in the wild has helped conserve other species that share its forest habitat.

FAST FACTS

- At least 23 percent of all mammals and 12 percent of all birds are threatened with extinction.
- Tropical coral reefs are likely to become extinct over the next 100 years.
- Protected areas such as wildlife reserves cover only 12.1 percent of Earth's land surface.

WILDLIFE RESERVES

Protecting endangered species often involves turning areas of land into wildlife reserves like this one on the African savanna. Other reserves protect wildernesses such as peat bogs, rainforests, or even coral reefs. Such places can pay for their cost of operation by earning money as tourist attractions.



CONSERVING HABITATS

Wildlife reserves are important, but they cover only small areas of the world—often far too small to secure the future of the wildlife that lives in them. This means that conservation efforts need to be coordinated over much wider areas, such as all forests, all wild grasslands, and all the oceans.

◀ FRAGILE BEAUTY

This woodland in northern England supports diverse wildlife, from tiny mosses and insects to lofty conifers. Such habitats are easily destroyed but almost impossible to replace.

